Life at the NDA was tough. The physical regimen aside, there was a fair deal of academics to deal with. I dare say that probably more cadets would have been relegated on academic grounds rather than on account of physical training (PT) tests. There are two streams at the NDA: a science stream divided into sections A to E, and a humanities stream with sections from 1 to 5. Since we were latecomers to the campus, we had to go separately to the academic department to get our streams allotted. Being a science student in school, I had opted for the science stream. I reported in turn to one of the assistants there, who on seeing my name, asked me in Marathi, '*Kiti takke milale*?' (What was your percentage? [score in the board exam]). I very proudly replied that I had secured a first division, with 64 per cent, no less. He looked me up and down, then at my marksheet and said, '*Saheb, tumhi mazha aika, non-science stream ghya*' (Sir, please listen to me, better take the non-science stream). He went on to explain that he had seen countless cadets, with even better grades, struggle with the twin demands of intense physical activity and academics and even toppers barely managed to pass. I went by his advice, and that's how, from a science student I became a humanities student and in hindsight, I can only say that I benefited greatly from this change. I narrated this story over tea to the administrative staff at the NDA, when I had gone there as Chief to review the passing-out parade of the 141st Course in October 2021, and they were greatly amused. My silent thanks to that person who gave me that most practical advice and because of whom, perhaps, I became the Chief.

I don't think that the ragging was too intense but apparently, somebody had kept a diary and shared that with his father who was a bigwig in the Services. We used to jokingly refer to it as the Odessa Files, after a movie that had been released at

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